ideas which you want to show but you cannot discuss with others," he says. "If I find something fascinating about a position and vice-versa, we discuss. We learn from each other."

This generation also has distinct personalities and playing styles. If Gukesh and Pragg step into the field with *vibhuti* on their foreheads, Divya's game mode is hair down and lipstick on. If Gukesh appears as impassive as a poker player, Vidit Gujrathi is all emotion when on the board. International Master Sagar Shah, who is also the founder and CEO of popular content platform ChessBase India, singles out their differences. "Gukesh has this huge ability for creative play at the board, Pragg has amazing endgame technique, Arjun has the ability to create complications which very few can navigate," says Shah. Their strong showing has seen India emerge as the second biggest market after the US for chess.com, the game's most popular website. That's 18.5 million registered users and a monthly active user base of 8 million. "In terms of viewership, we are the fastest growing market," says Avadh Shah, chess.com's country director for India.

85

No. of Indian GMs; only Russia, USA, Germany and Ukraine have more

3

No. of female GMs; Koneru Humpy, Harika Dronavalli and R. Vaishali are all active players

While Pragg and Vaishali have their mother, Nagalakshmi, accompanying them for tournaments, Gukesh relies on his father, Rajinikanth, an ENT specialist who put his practice on hold to travel with his son. Contrary to popular perception, chess is an expensive pursuit, with training fees coming at a hefty cost for families from middle-class backgrounds. Gukesh's mother Padmakumari, who teaches at the Madras Medical College (MMC), speaks of a time as recently as 2018-19 when the couple "had no money" to fund their son's dream to be the youngest Grandmaster, which in turn required participation in tournaments abroad. The Dommarajus had their batchmates from the MMC pool in money to help them out. "They were our first sponsors and we'll be grateful to them forever," says Padmakumari.

THE KING'S GAMBIT

The story of India's chess boom begins with the Covid pandemic when all the world was confined to their homes. The Netflix 2020 series, *The Queen's Gambit*, had generated a wave of interest in chess globally with many taking to playing chess online, but back home in

DIVYA DESHMUKH, 19 ▶

IM, World Junior Girls Champion



Boring. That was five-year-old Divya Deshmukh's first impression of chess until the competitive streak kicked in. "After I started playing tournaments, I wanted to finish on top of the table and be best at it," says Deshmukh, who is vying to be Nagpur's third GM and only the fourth female to achieve the honour. After a breakthrough 2024 which saw her clinch team gold and individual gold at the 45th Chess Olympiad in Budapest, become the girls' world junior champion and cross 2500 Elo ratings, Divya's goals for 2025 are simple: "Focus on mental and physical wellbeing, be healthy and happy."

